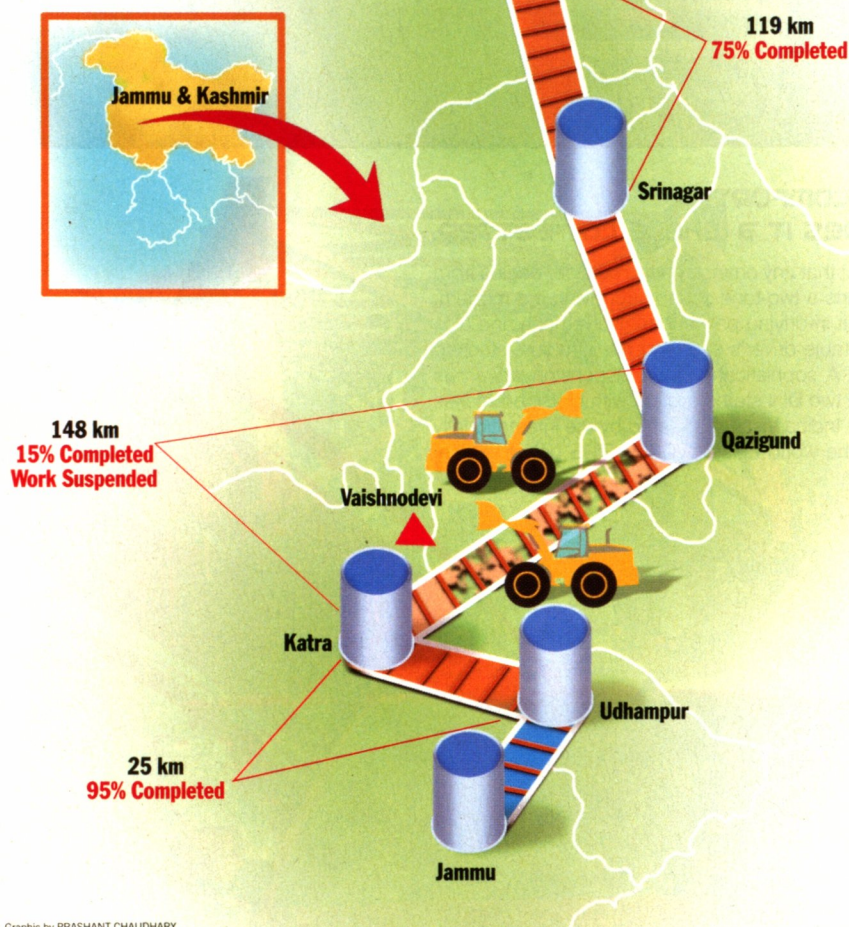


THE BROKEN LINK

Work on the main 148-km stretch has been suspended for technical reasons



Graphic by PRASHANT CHAUDHARY

supervised the work before Vij, counter the claim that the existing alignment is not feasible and also that work on the section had begun without proper surveys. "For the first time, the Railways used Digital Laser Terrain Modelling. Remote sensing and satellite imagery were used to get the exact alignment. It was mapped in great detail. Geological and seismic studies were conducted. Aerial surveys were also done. This was followed by physical surveys of most of the terrain," says a technical officer in the Railways.

That it is a prestige project is evident by the fact that Prime Minister

Manmohan Singh too has been tracking its progress. Alarmed by the turn of events, his office has asked for a status report on the project and reasons for stopping the work on the section. The decision to stop work has also invited queries from the Cabinet Secretariat, Planning Commission and the Finance Ministry. The Konkan Railway Construction Ltd (KRCL), in-charge of the disputed section, and Indian Railway Construction Company, which is constructing the adjoining section, have told the Railways that they have no problems with the present alignment but the

ministry has given written directions to KRCL not to commence any new work. The ministry's order says: "Other than the main road works, all works on the entire section with M/s KRCL be pended (sic) till further advice."

Jaruhar says, "We knew right from the beginning that Katra-Qazigund section is not going to be easy. We had to cross the Chenab and tunnel through the Pir Panjal ranges. But technically, we knew it was possible. It still is. Minor changes in alignment have been made along the way, and more can be made. A completely new alignment is a waste of money and time." In fact, it can push the deadline for completion of the line to as late as 2025. Vij presents a more optimistic picture. "Not before 2015," he says. Restarting the work on new alignment would take another five to seven years since the process will have to begin from scratch. The plan, according to the Railways' engineering chief, is to get a geological survey of the new proposed alignment done and follow it up with an on-the-ground survey. Following that, tenders would be called and awarded, and only then would work recommence. "We are going to get a geological survey done by an Austrian expert at a cost of Rs 10 crore. Meanwhile, an expert committee has been constituted to study the alignments and take a view," Vij says. The committee is still to be cleared by the railway minister, however.

Government sources say that, irrespective of the views of the committee, the Railways will have to go back to the Cabinet for any change in the alignment since it is a national project funded by the Government. Moreover, the line was envisioned more as a strategic and psychological project with international ramifications. The claims and counters only cloud the issue further. "The idea was to connect Kashmiris even in the remotest areas to the rest of the country. The new proposed alignment defeats the very idea. The existing alignment was chosen since it connects more than 50 villages, as against barely seven in the new one," says a senior bureaucrat.

Whatever the eventual fate of the project, its diplomatic and political impact means that politics, and not economics, will cast the final vote. Till then, the project stays derailed. ■



"The work on the section was wrong professionally and from the engineering point of view."

S. K. VIJ, RAILWAY BOARD MEMBER (ENGINEERING)